

RAM

ON SHAKY GROUND

■ The Archaeological Survey of India, in its affidavit to the Supreme Court, made the error of devaluing the epics to counter religious claims about the bridge.

■ Without conducting its own archaeological survey of the site, ASI opined that Adam's Bridge was a natural formation, basing it on studies done by the Geological Survey of India.

■ Experts who say ASI has been made a scapegoat are now calling for an archaeological search to decide the bridge's historicity. Meanwhile the issue has taken an ominous political turn.



torical record, we must give up altogether the historicity of Buddha or Mahavira." His reason: all the related inscriptions and sculptures of the two great religious leaders are of much later origin and not contemporary to their lives. Lal points to how Ashoka's Lumbini inscription, which is cited to proclaim the veracity of Buddha's birthplace, is ascribable to the 3rd century B.C., while the messiah was born 350 years earlier, in the 6th century B.C. Lal, though, does acknowledge that literary texts and oral tradition describing historical events must be used largely as supplementary evidence in the quest for truth.

Worse, ASI, for all its insistence on scientific proof, made sweeping statements without so much as wetting its hands to do some research on the origins of the Ram Sethu, as Adam's

nor UPA, made an effort to get ASI to study the region and determine whether the structure or any part of it was man-made, and if so, the antiquity of such a development.

ASI's main contention was that the Geological Survey of India (GSI) had made an in-depth study of the region and had declared the formation to be over 1,75,000 years old. The GSI study had categorically ruled out the existence of man-made structures, stating that the contours could be explained by natural causes. Curiously, the study was commissioned in 2002 by the then Union coal and mines minister Uma Bharati, whose role in the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992 is still under investigation. Experts say ASI should have been brought into the picture as well. It has an established marine archaeology wing and its findings would



THE CHANNEL

■ The 167-km-long shipping channel is meant to link the west coast of India to the eastern ports at a cost of Rs 2,427 crore.

■ It would reduce the steaming distance by 780 km and save 30 hours of sailing time as currently ships have to go around Sri Lanka.

Hadn't the country witnessed enough bloodletting over the Babri Masjid dispute in Ayodhya, Ram's place of birth?

More importantly, as B.B. Lal, former director-general of archaeology, an authority on archaeological evidence about Ram, says, ASI was going against professional grain when it made such a statement. He says: "If we insist on accepting only contemporary documents, whether these be in the form of an inscription or a written his-

Bridge is also known. It quite brazenly states in its affidavit that "there has been no occasion for ASI or GOI to even make a prima facie determination that the sand formation could be an ancient monument entitled to protection under the Act and therefore ASI has not undertaken any study in this regard". Which meant that despite the project being seriously considered for the past decade, neither the predecessor BJP-led government, with all its Ram fervour,

have given greater credibility to the GSI report. K.N. Dikshit, a former ASI joint DG, who was involved in the excavation of some of the Ram sites in India, points out: "While GSI can give the age of formation of geographical features, it may not be able to give conclusive proof of whether the human hand was present. For that, ASI experts should have been involved. Why weren't they?"

The Sethusamudram Corporation, which was established as a special purpose vehicle to implement the project, maintains that it engaged the public in the widest ever consultation over the project. Officials claim the reason why ASI was not asked for its opinion was that the issue of the reli-

"If we insist on contemporary documents, then we will have to question the historicity of Buddha and Mahavira."

B.B. LAL, FORMER DG, ASI